

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MICRONESIA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action in the Federated States of Micronesia is, distinctively among the nations in this series, as much about defending a genuine and hard-won success as about stopping a harm. Micronesia and its Pacific island neighbours have together achieved something genuinely rare in the world: small island states, by acting together, taking real collective control of the world's largest tuna fishery and managing it, through science-based limits on the fishing effort, for both revenue and long-term sustainability. Micronesia is a functioning constitutional democracy of four island states scattered across a vast and remote expanse of the western Pacific Ocean, its people deeply bound to the ocean that surrounds them, and its single defining environmental asset is its stewardship of the tuna that passes through its waters — a stewardship that turns the nation's sovereignty over its own seas into both income and genuine conservation. At the same time, the reefs, lagoons, and coastal fisheries that feed its island communities face genuine local pressures; the changing climate threatens both the islands and the very tuna the economy depends on; and the great industrial fishing fleets that come from distant nations must be held to the rules of the scheme. There is no dramatic "stop" to point to here. But there is a real success to defend, and the tools are genuine.

A community in Micronesia works to defend a genuine success and guard against harm, in a functioning democracy — and the tools are real. The distinctive lever is the **science-based tuna scheme and the collective control of the fishery**: small island states, acting together through the regional fisheries frameworks, hold the world's largest tuna fishery to science-based limits, and that scheme — and its enforcement against the **distant-water fleets** that must be held to its rules — is a genuine success to defend and strengthen. The **reefs, lagoons, and coastal fisheries** can be conserved through community-based management and the regional conservation commitment the island nations share. Major projects and harms must reckon with **environmental assessment**. The nation's **democratic and traditional governance** — national, state, and community, the elected institutions alongside the traditional authority — genuinely works; protest, petition, and democratic participation are lawful. And, as a small island state, Micronesia's voice in the **world's climate frameworks and diplomacy** is a real channel against the warming that threatens both islands and tuna. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The tuna scheme is a real and admirable success, so the aim is to defend and extend it, not to invent a crisis where none exists. But the success is fragile — threatened by weak enforcement, by the distant-water fleets, and by a changing climate that may move the fish itself beyond the nation's waters. The nation is small, remote, and economically dependent on fishing revenue and its compact, so its levers necessarily involve regional and international cooperation as much as domestic action. And no environmental effort here can halt the warming alone. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the tuna scheme defended and its rules enforced against the fleets, the reefs and coastal fisheries conserved, a harmful project assessed, the nation's climate voice raised — through the fisheries frameworks, the regional and community conservation, and the open democratic and traditional governance a functioning island democracy affords.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here mainly by defending and strengthening a genuine success. Guard the science-based tuna scheme and enforce its rules against the distant-water fleets; conserve the reefs and coastal fisheries

through community-based management and the regional conservation commitment; hold harmful projects to their environmental assessment; work the open democratic and traditional governance; and raise the nation's voice in the world's climate frameworks. The strongest ground here is not inventing a crisis but defending a real achievement against the threats that could undo it.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Micronesia is an open, hopeful setting with a genuine success to defend — a functioning democracy that, with its neighbours, controls the world's largest tuna fishery sustainably. Honesty about the harder truths is the first discipline. The success is fragile, threatened by weak enforcement, distant-water fleets, and a warming climate that may move the fish; the nation is small, remote, and economically dependent; and no effort here can halt the warming alone, so the levers involve regional and international cooperation as much as domestic action. So aim at the achievable — the scheme defended and enforced, the reefs conserved, a project assessed, the climate voice raised — through the fisheries frameworks, the regional conservation, and the open governance.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Micronesian decision runs through a functioning democracy, its neighbours, and the world. The **national and state governments and their fisheries and environment bodies** manage the tuna scheme, the assessments, and the reefs. The **regional fisheries frameworks and the island neighbours** collectively control the fishery and hold the fleets to the rules. The **traditional authority and communities** govern the reefs and coasts. And the **world's climate and conservation frameworks** give a small island state its wider voice. Map who decides — nationally, regionally, and traditionally — before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A harm — a distant-water fleet breaking the rules, a threat to a reef or coast, a domestic project — meets the scheme, the assessment, or the community governance. You enter through the fisheries frameworks and their enforcement for the fleets; the community-based management and regional conservation for the reefs; the environmental assessment for a project; and the traditional and democratic governance throughout. Enter through the success to defend and the open governance.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the tuna: which fleets fish the waters, under what days and rules of the scheme, and whether they comply. Follow the reefs: what threatens the coastal fisheries that feed communities. Follow the revenue: how the fishing income and the compact sustain the nation. Follow the climate: how the warming threatens the islands and may move the fish. The leverage lies in the tuna scheme and its enforcement, the community and regional conservation, and the assessment.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here genuinely function: the national and state fisheries and environment bodies, the regional fisheries frameworks that monitor the fleets, the traditional authority and communities that steward the reefs, the courts, and the world's climate and conservation frameworks. A case engages these, defending the success and guarding against harm.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Effort in Micronesia is genuinely effective at defending a real success, in a functioning democracy with collective control of its fishery. The single most decisive move is **defending and strengthening the science-based tuna scheme and enforcing its rules against the distant-water fleets**, because the scheme is a proven success and its collective, regional strength is real, and because holding the fleets to the rules is where the fishery is won or lost. The tuna scheme is the distinctive lever; the community and regional conservation the reefs' defence; the assessment the project gate; the climate diplomacy the wider voice. What the tools deliver is real — the scheme defended, the fleets held to the rules, the reefs conserved — though the warming is beyond the nation's sole control.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm or threat?** — a fleet breaking the scheme's rules, a threat to a reef or coast, a domestic project, the climate's pressure. **Which success does it touch?** — the tuna scheme, the reefs, the coastal fisheries. **What framework reaches it?** — the fisheries scheme and enforcement, the community and regional conservation, the assessment. **Which governance decides?** — national, state, traditional, or regional. **Is it within the nation's reach, or does it need the region and world?** — the climate and the fleets often do. Pick the fight where a proven framework and open governance give the clearest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm or threat** — the fleet's rule-breaking, the reef or coastal damage, the project's footprint, the climate pressure, documented with the science. **Layer two: the framework and the standard** — the tuna scheme's rules, the community and regional conservation commitments, the environmental-assessment requirements the harm breaches or strains. **Layer three: the governance and the reach** — which national, state, traditional, or regional body to engage, and where the region and world are needed. A case that defends the proven success and grounds harm in the scheme and the assessment is one Micronesia's institutions and its neighbours take seriously.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the fleet's compliance or breach, the reef or coastal damage, the project's footprint, the climate data. Gather the **framework record**: the tuna scheme's rules and enforcement, the community and regional conservation commitments, the assessment requirements. Gather the **success record**: the scheme's science-based limits and its results, to defend. Gather the **governance record**: the national, state, traditional, and regional bodies. Micronesia's open democracy and regional cooperation make much of this genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL AND REGIONAL SUPPORT

Micronesia's strength is a functioning democracy with both elected and traditional governance, and strong regional ties. Build with the **communities and traditional authority**, who steward the reefs and coasts; the **national and state fisheries and environment bodies**, who manage the scheme; the **regional fisheries and conservation partners**, whose collective strength holds the fleets; and the **island neighbours and international climate allies**. Frame the effort around defending a shared success and stewarding the reefs

— a cause that unites the elected, the traditional, and the regional, because the fishery and the ocean are the nation's common inheritance.

STEP 4: THE TUNA SCHEME, THE REEFS & THE OPEN GOVERNANCE — DEFENDING THE SUCCESS

Set expectations honestly: here the levers defend a genuine success, in a functioning democracy, though the fleets and the climate are real threats.

The Tuna Scheme and the Fleets

The distinctive lever is the **science-based tuna scheme and the collective control of the fishery**, held together through the regional frameworks — a genuine success to defend and strengthen. Its enforcement against the **distant-water fleets** that must obey its rules is where the fishery is guarded. Defend the scheme and hold the fleets to account.

The Reefs and the Regional Conservation

The **reefs, lagoons, and coastal fisheries** can be conserved through community-based management and the regional conservation commitment the island nations share, and major projects must reckon with **environmental assessment**. Steward the reefs through the community and the shared commitment.

The Open Governance and the Climate Voice

The nation's **democratic and traditional governance** genuinely works, and its voice in the **world's climate frameworks** is a real channel against the warming that threatens islands and tuna alike. Pursued together — the tuna scheme, the reef conservation, and the open governance and climate voice — these levers defend the success and guard against harm.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the fisheries bodies and regional frameworks**: here is a fleet breaking the scheme's rules, and a success to enforce. **For the community and traditional authority**: here are the reefs and coasts we steward together. **For the environment body**: here is a project needing proper assessment. **For the regional conservation partners**: here is the shared commitment to uphold. **For the world's climate frameworks**: here is a nation whose islands and fishery the warming threatens. **The golden rule**: defend the proven success, enforce the scheme against the fleets, steward the reefs through the community and region, and raise the nation's climate voice — through the open democratic and traditional governance.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In a functioning democracy, media supports both defence and stewardship. Frame the story around **the success and the stewardship**: a rare achievement — small island states controlling the world's largest tuna fishery sustainably — and the reefs and coasts the communities steward, threatened by rule-breaking fleets and a warming climate. Carry it through the national, regional, and international press and the climate and conservation networks. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the science and the scheme; frame it as defending a real success, not inventing a crisis; and let the achievement, the science, and the shared ocean carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the scheme and the science, and framed around defending a success.

8A — To the fisheries body or regional framework: document a fleet breaking the scheme's rules and press for enforcement.

8B — To the traditional authority and community: coordinate the community-based stewardship of a reef or coast.

8C — To the environment body: request proper assessment of a harmful project.

8D — To a regional conservation partner: uphold the shared conservation commitment.

8E — On the distant-water fleets: press the collective, regional enforcement of the scheme's rules.

8F — To an international climate framework: raise the nation's voice against the warming threatening islands and tuna.

8G — To the national or state government: defend and strengthen the tuna scheme and the reefs.

8H — To the press and public: tell the story of a rare success to defend, and the stewardship of the shared ocean.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: identify the harm — a rule-breaking fleet, a reef threat, a project — and the framework that reaches it; document it; write the one-page case framed as defending the success. **The fastest-moving levers:** the tuna scheme's enforcement, the community and regional conservation, and the assessment.

Emergency action: for a fleet breaking the rules, the regional fisheries enforcement; for a reef, the community and regional conservation; for a project, the assessment. Throughout, defend the proven success rather than inventing a crisis.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted less by domestic villainy than by external threats: distant-water fleets, a warming climate, and economic dependence. Recognise it, and lean on the levers that fit — the collective, regional strength of the tuna scheme against the fleets, the community and regional conservation of the reefs, and the nation's climate voice in the world's frameworks. In Micronesia these genuinely work. And accept, honestly, that the success is fragile, that the warming and the fleets are beyond the nation's sole control, and that the levers involve regional and international cooperation as much as domestic action.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Micronesia is a functioning democracy, so the more usual challenge is not domestic capture but the pressure of distant-water fleets and the fragility of enforcement. Where a fleet evades the rules or a project is favoured against the assessment, respond through the open channels the nation genuinely provides: the fisheries bodies and regional frameworks, the environment authorities, the traditional and democratic governance, the courts, and the regional and international partners. **On safety:** Micronesia is a peaceful,

rule-of-law democracy; the risks here are not physical but the fragility of a success that must be actively defended. So the work is open, lawful, and collaborative — regional as much as domestic — and framed around defending a genuine achievement.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel. The documented harm feeds the scheme's enforcement, the reef conservation, and the assessment at once; the communities, traditional authority, and regional partners organise together; the media tells the story of a success to defend throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and engage the fisheries, environment, or community body; **months two to six**, press the scheme's enforcement, the reef conservation, and the assessment, and engage the regional and climate partners; **beyond**, defend and strengthen the success. The core discipline: success-defending, science-grounded, and regional as much as domestic.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Effort in Micronesia is genuinely effective, and distinctively so, because it defends a real and admirable success — a functioning democracy that, with its Pacific neighbours, controls the world's largest tuna fishery through science-based limits, for both revenue and conservation. This guide has been honest that the aim is to defend and extend that success, not to invent a crisis; that the success is fragile, threatened by weak enforcement, distant-water fleets, and a warming climate that may move the fish; and that the nation is small, remote, and dependent, so its levers involve regional and international cooperation as much as domestic action. But those honest truths do not weaken the effort — they focus it. A community that defends and strengthens the tuna scheme and enforces its rules against the fleets, conserves the reefs and coastal fisheries through community-based management and the regional commitment, holds harmful projects to their assessment, and raises the nation's voice in the world's climate frameworks — through the open democratic and traditional governance — can genuinely guard the ocean that sustains it. The tools are real, the success is proven, and the distinctive strength is that here the fight is, above all, to defend an achievement the whole world could learn from.